

Flock Safety cameras spark privacy debate in Paducah

John Yeley

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PADUCAH — Across the country, an increasing number of cities are ending their contracts with Flock Safety, the company that provides AI-powered license plate-reading cameras for law enforcement nationwide. Concerns have been raised about how the data is being collected and used, with some calling it an invasion of privacy amid fears of unauthorized federal access.

Paducah resident Jason Duffey said he understands the need for cameras in public areas but doesn't see the need for them in residential areas, such as his own.



A Flock Safety camera points at the road off Kentucky Avenue on June 24.

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“I don’t really find that to be the proper use of using a Flock camera, because the purpose is to protect or help the police with people maybe moving different places in and out of the city, but putting a Flock camera in a residential area facing individuals’ properties, that is a concern to me, because that’s constant monitoring,” said Duffey.

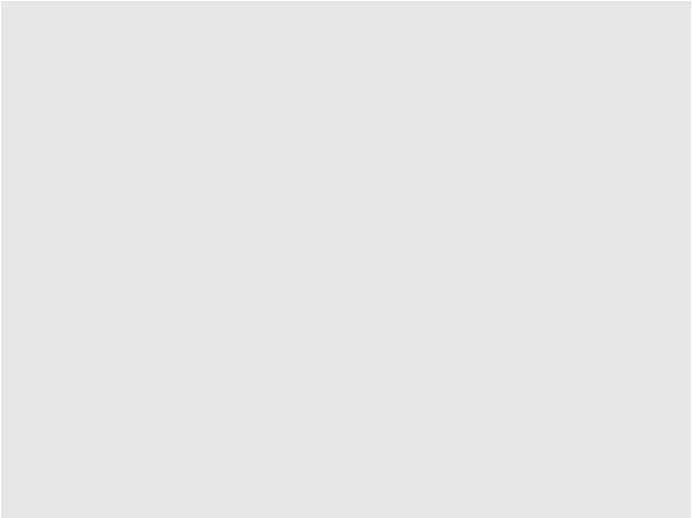
As that concern grows locally, Paducah Police Chief Brian Laird explained how the Flock cameras have been beneficial, adding that policies are in place to protect the collected data.

“I think it’s important for the community to know that we have strict policies related to accessing that data; for our officers to have access to that data, there has to be a reason, and that’s documented. We conduct audits quarterly on access into the Flock system,” said Laird.

According to NPR, **more than 30 cities** across the country have halted the use of Flock cameras. One notable example includes Denver, Colorado. **The city removed 110 flock cameras at the end of March**, citing concerns about how the company handles the potentially sensitive information the systems gather on citizens.

“We do share our information or access into our camera systems with hundreds of police departments all across the country, so that’s important, because they also share that with us, and without that sharing of information, we wouldn’t be as successful in preventing and stopping crime,” said Laird.

Laird noted that Flock cameras have been in use in Paducah for four years now and have achieved demonstrable results. Furthermore, Laird does not believe the system is being misused.



“We do not think that it’s something that is being abused here in our community. It’s been very successful, and we look forward to, you know, a good partnership and utilizing that resource. You know, policing has to evolve because the criminals are evolving, and in order to keep a community safe, you should utilize any resources that

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you have available to you, obviously, with keeping people's rights in mind as well," said Laird.

Duffey remained unconvinced of the practicality of the current tactics being utilized with the technology.

"I don't think it's really a proper use of government funding," he said. "You know, those cameras are expensive, and the service is expensive, and I don't really think the city or any of the residents understand how it works, and when you use it in a way where it's not disclosed, and you don't disclose it to the residents of the neighborhood, I don't really feel like that is proper use of police enforcement."

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"They've been pretty effective for us with crime — fighting crime, stopping crime," Laird said. "We implemented them initially as a trial period with two cameras, and then each year since then we've increased the number. The goal was to strategically place them throughout the city on the main thoroughfares so that if there are vehicles that are coming into our city that are suspects in crimes or they're stolen vehicles or missing persons that we would be able to locate them — especially the ones that are coming here to commit crime — before they actually do so."

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